

● ONGOING · NO CONTAINER RECOVERY

SUPPLY-CHAIN DISRUPTION BRIEF

Two years on, the Suez Canal is back to half strength – and containers haven't returned at all

Total transits have partly recovered on the back of tankers and bulk. Container shipping stayed on the Cape route, and the data shows no trend back.

By Michael Schertz Tooling [logjam](#) (open-source) Generated 30 Aug 2026 Source IMF PortWatch
Method see § Method & provenance

SUEZ TOTAL TRANSITS 55 % of normal 42/day now vs 76 pre-crisis	SUEZ CONTAINER TRANSITS 46 % of normal No recovery trend in nine quarters
SUEZ CONTAINER CAPACITY 26 % of normal Only the smaller feeders still transit	CAPE OF GOOD HOPE CONTAINERS +233 % 6 → 20 transits/day

§ 1 The finding

Two and a half years on, the Suez Canal carries about **55% of its pre-crisis traffic** – and for containers, essentially none of it has come back.

IMF PortWatch counts vessel transits at 28 maritime chokepoints from satellite AIS. Through the Suez Canal, total transits averaged **76 per day** in the clean quarter before the December 2023 escalation of attacks on Red Sea shipping. In July 2026 they averaged **42 per day** — a partial recovery from the 2024 trough, but still a third below normal.

Split by cargo class, the recovery is lopsided. Tanker transits are back to **63%** of pre-crisis. Container transits sit at **46%** — 9 per day against 20 before — and container *capacity* through the canal is at just **26%**. The box trade did not slow down and recover; it left.

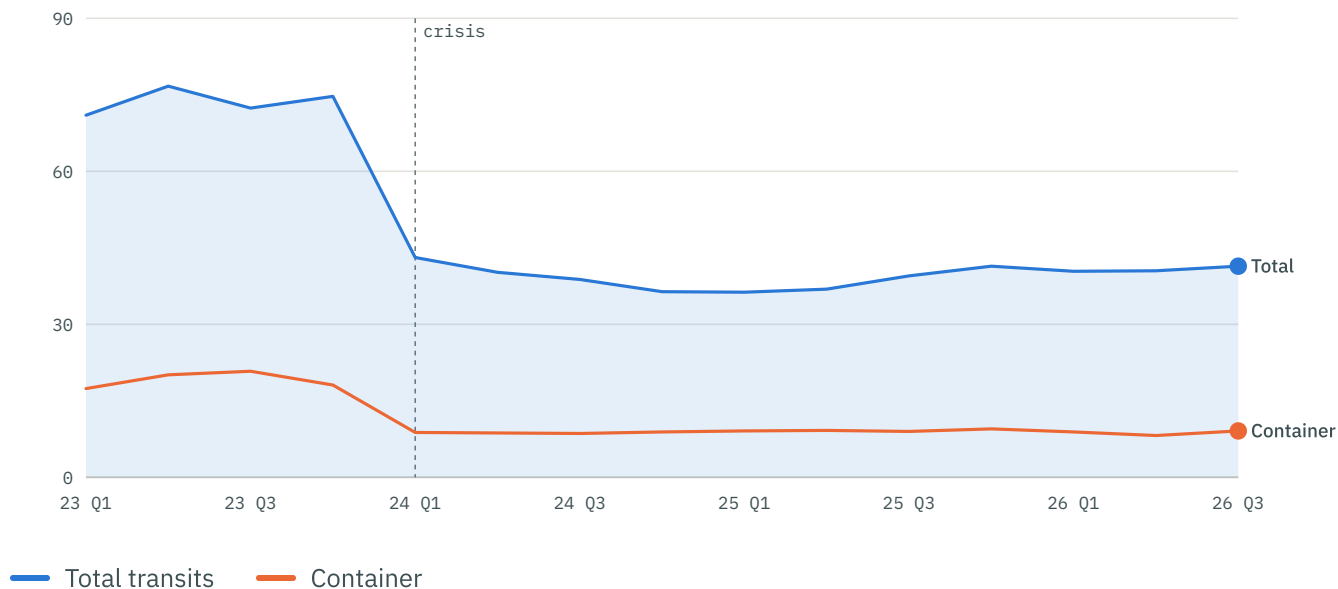
§ 2 The diversion held

The break is visible as a single step down in the first quarter of 2024 and a flat line since. There is no upward trajectory in the container series across nine quarters — the disruption is not resolving, it has become the operating baseline.

Total transits have ground back a little, from the 2024 low toward 42 per day, entirely on the back of tankers and dry bulk. Those cargoes are more willing to price in the war-risk insurance premium and the longer exposure; container lines, running fixed weekly schedules, rerouted wholesale and have stayed rerouted.

Suez Canal transits per day — total vs container

Quarterly average, 2023 Q1 – 2026 Q3



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data, fields n_total and n_container. Marker: December 2023 escalation.

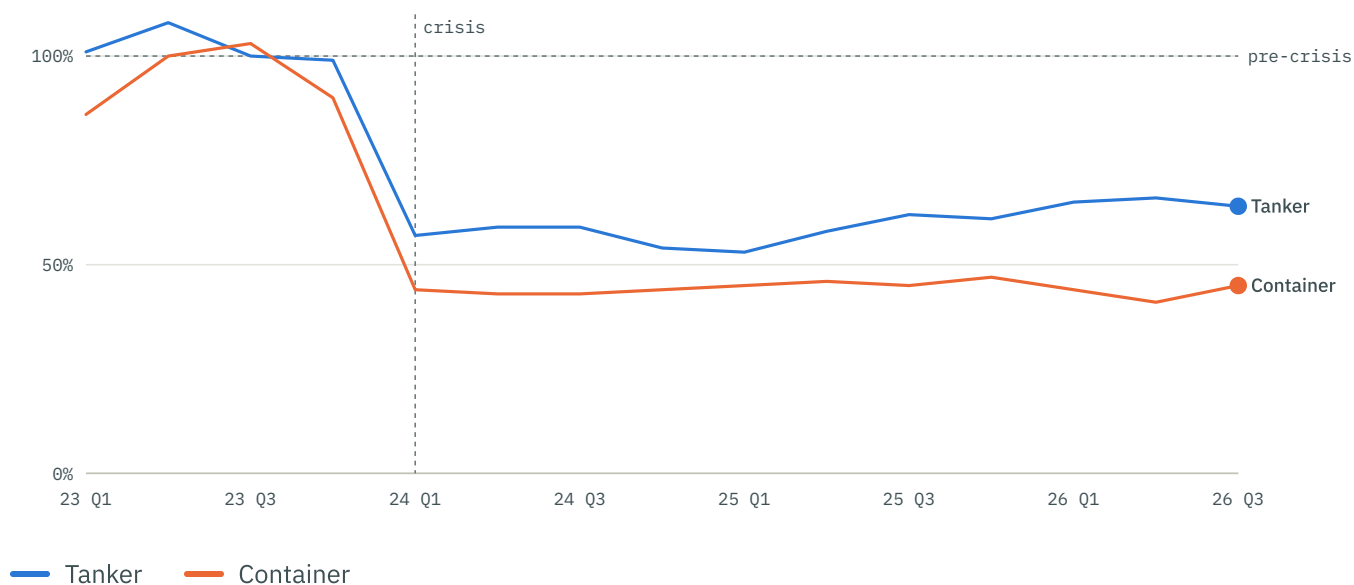
§ 3 Blocked for boxes, not for barrels

Indexing each cargo class to its own pre-crisis average makes the split unmistakable. Tankers and dry bulk have clawed back toward normal; containers are pinned near the floor. Container cargo capacity — the aggregate slot capacity of the ships still using the canal — is at **26% of normal**, below even the vessel count, because the container ships that do transit are the smaller feeders, not the 20,000-TEU mainliners.

A uniform collapse across every class would point to a hard closure. This selective pattern is the signature of a commercial reroute: the route is open, but for scheduled container services the math no longer works.

Recovery by cargo class — Suez Canal

Indexed to the Sep–Nov 2023 average (= 100), quarterly



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data. Each series divided by its own pre-crisis mean.

WHY THIS MATTERS

A transit count alone could be read as “slowly recovering.” Capacity confirms it is not: for containers, real throughput through Suez is a small fraction of what it was, and flat.

§ 4 The Cape took the load

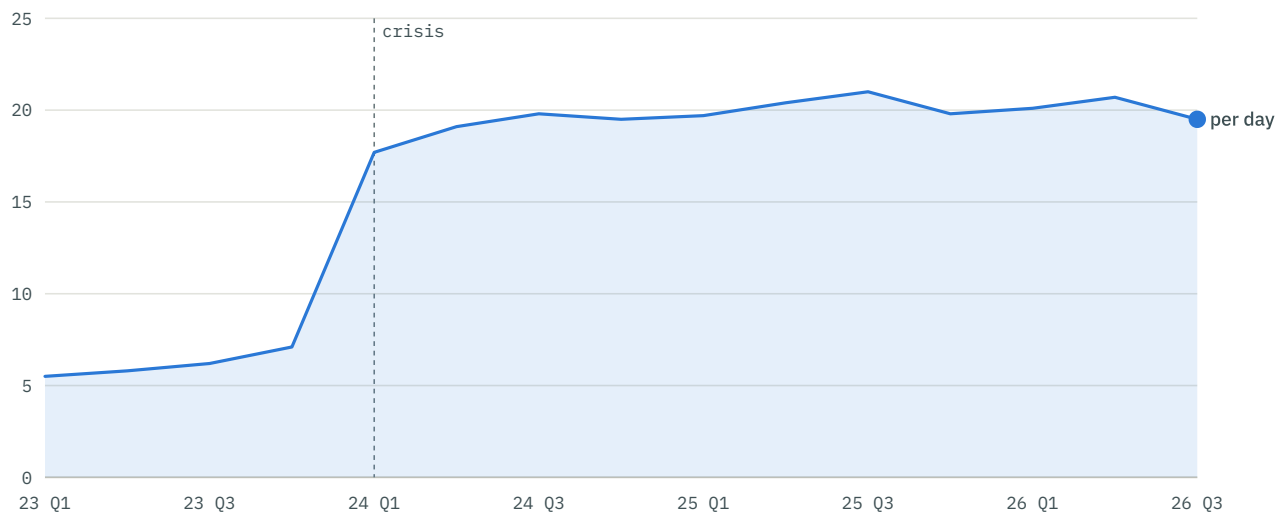
Every box that left the Red Sea route had to go somewhere. It went around Africa — and has stayed there.

Container transits past the Cape of Good Hope have risen from **6 per day** pre-crisis to **20 per day** — up **+233%** — and container cargo capacity on the route is up **+526%**, from 193,096 to 1,208,567 per day. The Cape line shows the same single step in early 2024 as Suez, in the opposite direction, and the same flat plateau since.

The cost is distance. Asia–North Europe via the Cape is roughly 3,500 nautical miles and 10–14 days longer than via Suez, which ties up ships, burns bunkers, and has kept effective fleet capacity tight across the whole Asia–Europe trade for two years.

Cape of Good Hope — container transits per day

Quarterly average, 2023 Q1 – 2026 Q3



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data, field n_container, chokepoint 7.

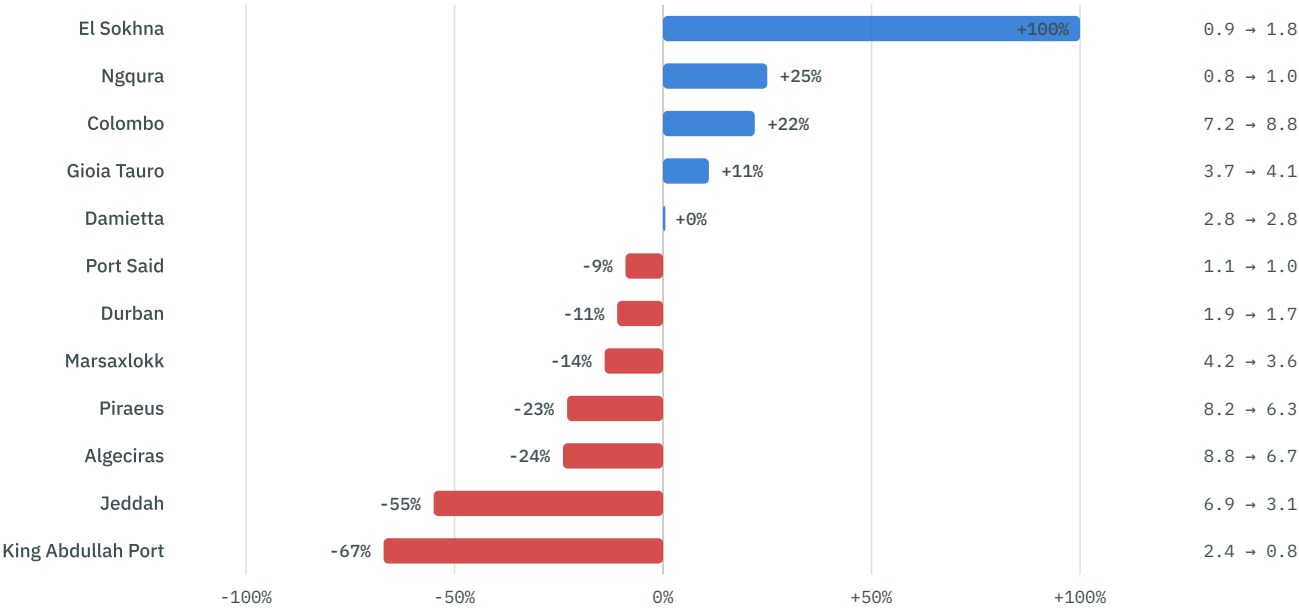
§ 5 Who lost the transshipment

There is no clear port-level winner, because the reroute is a longer version of the same voyage rather than a switch to a new hub. The clear *losers* are the Mediterranean transshipment hubs that fed the Suez route: Marsaxlokk -14%, Piraeus -23%, Algeiras -24%. They handled Asia-origin boxes that came through the canal for onward distribution; that feeder role has thinned.

Egypt's own canal-adjacent container ports (Port Said, Damietta) are roughly flat — they were never the point of the route. The one consistent gainer is **Colombo**, up as a consolidation point where Asian cargo is aggregated onto the big ships before the long haul around the Cape.

Change in container port calls — July 2026 vs pre-crisis

Percent change in daily port-call average, Sep–Nov 2023 baseline



Source: IMF PortWatch, `Daily_Ports_Data`, field `portcalls_container`. Absolute rates (calls/day, pre-crisis → July) at right — small ports swing large percentages off a low base.

§ 6 Assessment

The Suez Canal in 2026 is a structurally smaller artery. Mixed traffic has stabilised near **55% of pre-crisis**; containerised trade shows **no recovery trend** after nine quarters and runs at well under half its former volume. The Cape of Good Hope is the load-bearing alternative and there is no sign of that unwinding.

Two caveats bound this read. PortWatch measures vessel movements, not their causes — the 2024 break coincides with the reported Red Sea shipping crisis, but the data attests to the outcome. And the pre-crisis window is a fixed 2023 quarter; that is the right comparison for a structural shift of this kind, but it means every figure here is “versus 2023,” not versus a hypothetical undisrupted 2026.

Quarterly figures — Suez Canal and the Cape route, container traffic

QUARTER	SUEZ TOTAL/DAY	SUEZ CONTAINER/DAY	SUEZ CONTAINER CAPACITY/DAY	CAPE CONTAINER/DAY
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QUARTER	SUEZ TOTAL/DAY	SUEZ CONTAINER/DAY	SUEZ CONTAINER CAPACITY/DAY	CAPE CONTAINER/DAY
23 Q1	71	17.4	927,781	5.5
23 Q2	77	20.1	1,079,368	5.8
23 Q3	72	20.8	1,120,938	6.2
23 Q4	75	18.1	995,616	7.1
24 Q1	43	8.8	247,479	17.7
24 Q2	40	8.7	177,004	19.1
24 Q3	39	8.6	179,270	19.8
24 Q4	36	8.9	185,571	19.5
25 Q1	36	9.1	198,586	19.7
25 Q2	37	9.2	189,904	20.4
25 Q3	40	9.0	190,464	21.0
25 Q4	41	9.5	200,909	19.8
26 Q1	40	8.9	208,021	20.1
26 Q2	40	8.2	226,903	20.7
26 Q3	41	9.1	295,789	19.5

§ Method & provenance

Every figure in this brief is reproducible from a local database built by the open-source `logjam` tool and a single generator script. Nothing is hand-transcribed.

DATA SOURCE

IMF PortWatch (portwatch.imf.org) — daily maritime activity estimated from satellite AIS on ~90,000 ships, via the UN Global Platform. Free public use with attribution. Backfill covers 1 Jan 2023 – 23 Aug 2026.

WHAT THE NUMBERS ARE

`n_total` / `n_container` / `n_tanker` are counts of vessel transits by class.
`capacity_container` is the estimated aggregate cargo capacity of transiting container ships.
`portcalls_container` is container-ship port calls.

BASELINE

A fixed pre-crisis window, **September–November 2023** — the last clean quarter before the December 2023 escalation — not a rolling baseline, which by 2026 would treat the diverted level as normal. Percent-of-normal = current value ÷ pre-crisis mean.

“CURRENT” MONTH

July 2026. PortWatch revises its most recent ~2 weeks upward as satellite data lands, so the latest month in the store is still settling and is not used for headline figures.

REROUTE ANALYSIS

The Cape of Good Hope is the route substitute (`n_container`, chokepoint 7). Port-level comparison on `portcalls_container`, July 2026 vs the same 2023 window, for East Mediterranean transshipment hubs, Egyptian canal ports, Colombo, and South African / Red Sea ports.

REPRODUCE

Clone github.com/ubeast/logjam, backfill the database to 2023, then `uv run python scripts/reports/suez_redsea_2026.py`. Full method in `docs/METHODOLOGY.md`.

Limitations

- PortWatch measures throughput (vessels moving), not queue length, berth dwell, or voyage duration. This brief cannot quantify the added transit time around the Cape beyond the standard distance estimate.
- The data attests to the shipping outcome, not the cause. The Q1 2024 break coincides with the reported Red Sea crisis; causation is not established here.
- Capacity and trade-volume fields are model estimates, not manifest data.
- All comparisons are versus a fixed 2023 quarter — “versus pre-crisis,” not versus a counterfactual undisrupted 2026.
- Port-level effects are shown only for a hand-picked candidate set; an unlisted beneficiary or casualty would be missed.